The call overwriter's guide: Identifying stocks for single stock call selling

Derivatives Strategy

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- Selling calls on top of existing equity positions can be an appealing way to earn additional yield, but caps the total achievable return on the underlying equity positions.
- Prudent structuring of the call overwriting program is crucial in our view to balance the trade-offs between a high option income and a low likelihood of being exercised on the option.
- Stock selection and active management can improve outcomes in our view, by increasing performance through a focus on the right parameters. We outline an active approach with our single stock methodology.

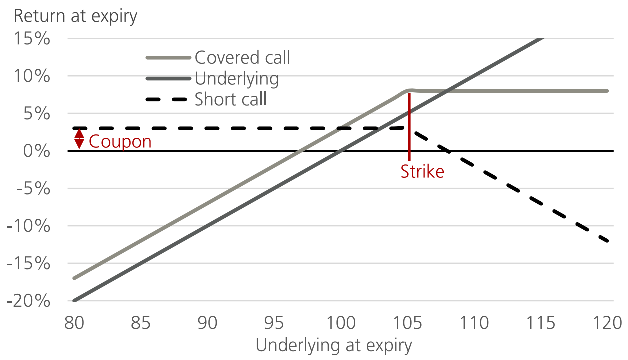
Overwriting an income diversifier

Selling calls on existing equity positions has become a more widely used strategy among investors seeking to generate additional returns from their holdings, as illustrated by the growth of related ETF products. In our view, such strategies can serve multiple purposes and use cases. Tactically, investors can use them to monetize volatility on underlying assets in which they have less positive conviction over the short to medium term. Alternatively, systematic implementations can help create a more defensive risk-return profile for equity positions. Additionally, they can potentially enhance income generation, which may be of particular interest to income-focused investors seeking a diversified portfolio across asset classes. Figure 1 compares the payoff profile of a covered call structure with a direct investment in the underlying asset.

However, investors should note that the payoff profile will only match the illustration at expiry. Before expiration, option sensitivities—such as changes in the underlying price and volatility—can affect daily mark-to-market returns. A covered call strategy can be viewed as combining a long position in the underlying asset with a short volatility position. As a result, a covered call provides exposure to both equity and volatility risk premia. Option sellers are typically compensated for the risk of being short options, as implied volatility (used to price options) tends to be higher than the ex-ante expected volatility.

Figure 1 - Payoff profile of covered call

Illustrative payoff profile of a covered call on an underlying compared to the underlying itself. Initial spot at 100 and strike of call 5% OTM, call pays a premium of 2.5%.



Source: UBS, as of May 2026.

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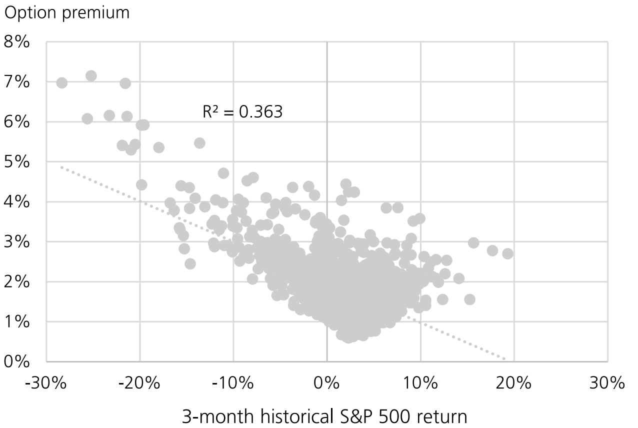
While selling calls caps upside potential and limits returns in the event of strong upward moves, the generated option income has the potential to enhance returns relative to an outright long position in downward or slightly upward trending markets. Importantly, the correlation between option income and equity returns tends to be negative, as implied volatility—and thus option prices—typically rise when markets fall. Figure 2 highlights this relationship between the option premium of at-the-money, three-month calls and returns for the S&P 500 index over the previous three months.

Figure 2 - Negative correlation between equity returns and option premium

Comparison between option premium of three-month, at-the-money calls and subsequent three-month S&P 500 return



Source: Bloomberg, UBS, as of May 2026.

In the following analysis, we focus on single stock call writing strategies. We use a data set from 2010 to 2025 covering all stocks in USD, EUR, GBP and CHF which are or have been constituents of the MSCI World index.

Structuring call-writing overlays

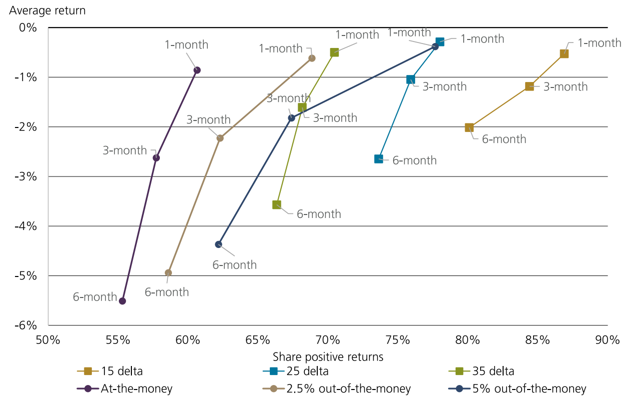
An important aspect when writing calls on equity investments such as indexes or single stocks is the structuring of the option parameters, i.e., tenor and strike, which will in turn define the option premium. In our view there are best practices with which investors can potentially increase both the likelihood of positive returns as well as expected returns in general.

In Figure 3, we compare average returns across time, as well as the share of positive returns across different option tenors and striking methods.

Selling shorter-dated options, e.g., one-month tenors, performs better over the long-term vs. longer-dated structures. From an equity perspective this should not come as a surprise. Equity markets tend to rise over time, therefore longer-dated structures are more likely to expire in the money. In theory, higher volatility, through an upward shaped volatility term structure curve, should compensate for the risk of more frequent expiries in the money. Our analysis shows that this while volatility for longer-dated options is typically higher, it does not fully offset the more frequent losses. Making shorter-dated structures more attractive on average, in our view.

Figure 3 - Option structuring is key

Comparison of average annualized returns and share of positive returns across different striking methodologies, i.e., fixed strike and fixed delta.



Source: Bloomberg, UBS, as of May 2026. Note that past performance is not a reliable indicator of future results, please see the back-test disclaimer at the end of this document. Performance includes a bid-ask approximation, but not additional costs.

In terms of option striking we believe a defensive approach is relatively more attractive, especially for investors considering systematic single stock option overlays. For shorter-dated options, such as one-month and three-month tenors, average returns are typically relatively similar across aggressive and defensive option structuring. However, more defensive structuring (i.e., lower delta, which translates to higher strikes and lower option premia) typically delivers a higher frequency of positive returns. Hence, investors looking at systematic call overwriting strategies would have been better off by selling shorter-dated options when looking to maximize absolute returns.

Nevertheless, average returns of selling call options across the full stock universe would have been negative across all option tenors in our sample period. Meaning that given the strong performance in equity markets during the sample period from 2011 to 2025 selling naked calls would have delivered a negative return and not compensated for the incurred risks. This makes an active investment approach a critical addition of such overwriting strategies, in our view. There are different approaches investors can consider. The first is to improve call overwriting strategies via a delta hedging approach in order to isolate the volatility premium. The second is via active timing and sizing of the call overlay, e.g. by not overwriting during unfavorable market regimes. The third is by active underlying selection, i.e. actively selecting stocks for the overwriting program.

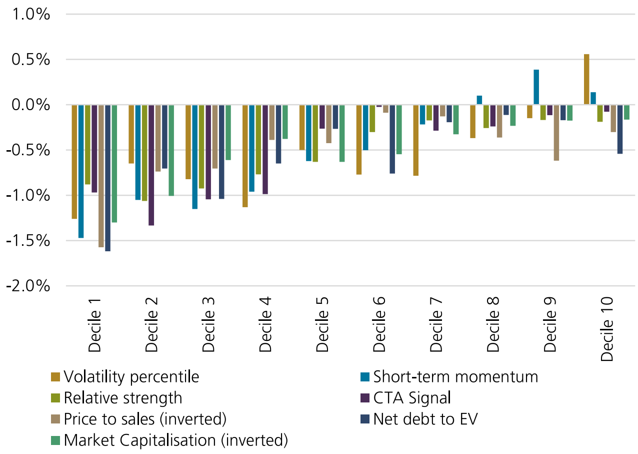
In search of the good calls

Our research shows that there are statistical metrics that can help investors identify stocks which are relatively appealing for call overwriting strategies. Short-dated price momentum and implied volatility are some of the key metrics. In our analysis we focus on 1-month, 15-delta calls.

Stocks that have performed strongly in the recent past, are likely to exhibit mean reversion according to our analysis. This means that in the short-term, i.e., over a 1- to 3-months' time horizon, the best performing stocks are less likely to exhibit a continuation of the recent strong performance. This is in line with previous empirical finace research. Selling calls on recent outperformers is, on average, a better strategy than selling calls on underperformers. Price momentum can be calculated in different ways, e.g., via short-term price performance, relative-strength metrics or other technical indicators. In our view, an aggregate of different metrics is typically the most robust approach.
Volatility metrics have historically also shown some predictive power in identifying suitable stocks for call overwriting. We compare a stock's current implied volatility to its own 1-year history. Stocks with relatively elevated volatility typically are more attractive candidates for option selling structures. However, this varies across volatility regimes. Especially, during periods of very high volatility this relationship is less strong. Fig. 4 compares average returns by decile portfolios across a selection of different explanatory variables.

Figure 4 - Factors driving call performance

Average return of selling 1-month, 15-delta calls for decile portfolios



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Next to price momentum and volatility metrics we see value in considering other parameters, such as valuation metrics. We think that by including a combination of fundamental metrics, which we call the hype factor, call overwriting strategies can be further improved. We use two variables to determine the hype factor: price-to-sales ratio and the net-debt to Enterprise value.

In our view, selling call options on stocks with a high price-to-sales ratio is particularly unattractive, and vice versa. There is an intuitive explanation in our view. Stocks with a high price-to-sales ratio are typically high growth stocks, with relatively optimistic projections about future growth potential. However, they are also more likely to exhibit strong upward moves making selling calls relatively less attractive even if volatility is high and short-term price momentum is positive.

A similar case can be made for net-debt to enterprise value. Stocks with relatively low debt levels compared to company value likewise tend to be high growth companies and may either fall or gain in value significantly. Again, in such cases, selling calls is less attractive compared to selling calls on stocks with relatively high levels of debt to company valuation.

Lastly, selling call options on stocks with high market capitalization is typically less profitable than selling calls on relatively smaller companies. Note that, since our universe consists only of stocks in the MSCI World Index and excludes companies with a market capitalization below USD 5bn, the investable universe is already artificially restricted, with a tilt toward global mid- and large-cap stocks. We see two drivers that may support this finding. First, the trend toward indexed investment may have supported more flows into the largest companies, supporting outperformance over time, as suggested by recent financial research. Second, the gain in popularity of overwriting strategies may make upside calls on the largest single stock names relatively unattractive, whereas there is more room for active selection in the smaller large-cap stocks.

Lastly, it is important to remember that trading a stock, and an option on the stock, is not the same thing. In essence, the best performing stock may not be the most attractive one on which to buy an option on, and vice versa. While there is a strong, positive correlation between the performance of a stock and a long position in a call option, an investor who either buys or sells an option is also exposed to the implied volatility used to price the option. Hence, an option investor trades both the underlying price and the volatility, which makes option investing—and selecting interesting underlying to buy or sell options—fundamentally different than identifying attractive or unattractive stocks for outright long positions. Option investors therefore require additional tools and research in order to make informed decisions.

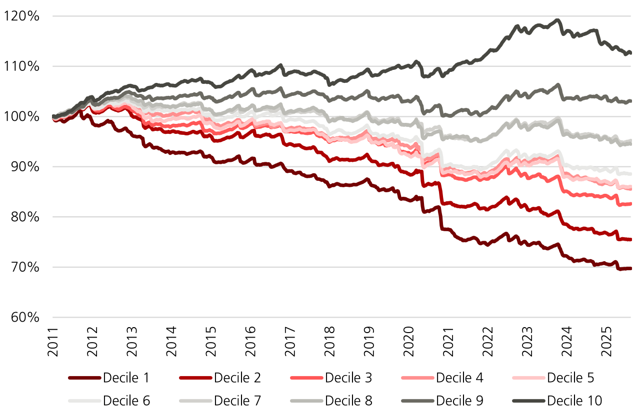
A systematic approach

We transform our preferred metrics into a simple, systematic factor model to assess the relative attractiveness of call writing across our stock universe. The model assigns a composite score to each stock which we use to rank and sort the universe into ten equally sized decile portfolios at each rebalancing date. Decile 1 contains the 10% of stocks with the lowest scores (least attractive for call writing), while decile 10 contains the 10% with the highest scores (most attractive).

Figure 5 illustrates the simulated performance of a systematic call overwriting strategy applied to decile portfolios from 2011 to 2025. Each week, the stock universe is ranked according to updated factor scores and divided into ten equally sized decile portfolios. On each stock, the strategy sells a one-month, 15-delta call option; positions are held to expiry. The simulation incorporates a bid-ask approximation based on the volatility of the stock, but no management fee. Our results reveal a pronounced performance gradient: higher decile portfolios, representing stocks with more attractive factor profiles, consistently deliver superior returns. These findings underscore the value of factor-based stock selection in enhancing the effectiveness of call overwriting strategies.

Figure 5 - Factor model produces good split

Cumulative returns of selling systematic call options (for 1-month 15-delta options). Decile 1 relates to 10% of stocks scoring the worst, decile 10 stock scoring the best.



Source: Bloomberg, UBS, as of May 2026. Note that past performance is not a reliable indicator of future results, please see the back-test disclaimer at the end of this document. Performance includes a bid-ask approximation, but not additional costs.

Stocks that rank highly within our framework consistently prove to be more attractive candidates for call overwriting over the long term. For example, the top decile portfolio (Decile 10) would have generated a positive total return by systematically selling calls on single stocks, whereas selling calls on lower-ranked stocks would have resulted in losses that did not adequately compensate for the associated risks.

Our results appear robust across time: conducting the analysis on different historical sub-periods yields consistent conclusions. This suggests that the key drivers identified by our framework have been persistent in the past. However, past performance is not indicative of future results, and there is no assurance that these drivers will retain their predictive power going forward.
A key advantage of this approach is its ability to facilitate active allocation across different volatility regimes. This is achieved by integrating a volatility metric that ranks each stock's current volatility percentile relative to its own historical distribution, and then comparing these percentiles across the universe. This dynamic framework enables more responsive and effective cross sectional split across stocks than using other volatility metrics.

Figure 6 - Volatility sensitivity proves effective

Difference in average volatility between stocks in decile portfolio 1 and 10 compared to average single stock implied volatility. Measured across full universe for 1-month, at-the-money calls.

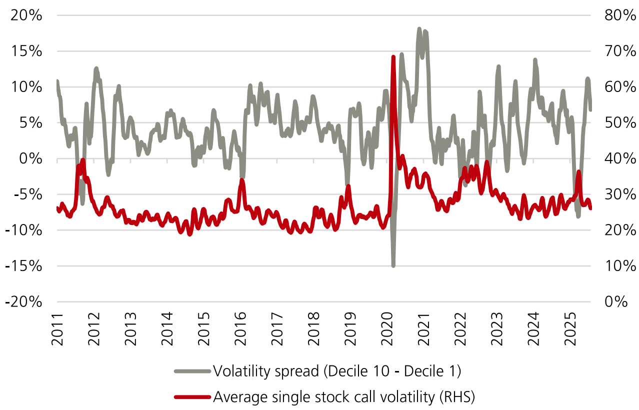


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Figure 6 displays the outcome. In periods of high volatility, such as during the market sell-offs, the selection would tilt away from high volatility stocks, as illustrated by the difference in average volatility of the 10% of stocks that score the highest and 10% of stocks which score the lowest. The difference is typically positive, especially when markets are calm, highlighting a tilt toward high volatility stocks. This relationship, however, changes during periods of severe market stress, such as during the drawdown in 2020 or in April 2025 when our percentile-based volatility metric becomes less meaningful as volatility across all stocks is relatively elevated. Hence, our model approach would apply more weight to the other metrics in our systematic approach. Our analysis suggests that such a volatility metric is more useful than scoring for absolute levels of volatility.

These findings highlight the critical importance of stock selection in option selling strategies—an insight that applies to both call and put options, as discussed in our previous publication, "The CIO option search engine: Ranking stocks for income generation." Notably, the choice between selling calls or puts depends on distinct factors, as our research suggests that upside and downside asymmetry are driven by different drivers. This requires tailored modeling approaches for both cases and highlights the differences between investing in options and the underlying.

A tale of two systematic approaches

We see two use cases for incorporating our research on single-stock call overwriting strategies into investment strategies and broader asset allocation. The first is to enhance call overwriting overlays, thereby building more robust frameworks for call selling. The second is to identify stocks with relatively cheap upside volatility, where call buying may be an attractive strategy.

Optimizing the overwrite

One application of our research is to refine call overwriting strategies by selectively overwriting only certain stocks within an equity portfolio, or by selling a higher notional of calls on stocks that screen well in our framework compared to those that do not. This targeted approach may improve the overall effectiveness of an overwrite strategy.

To illustrate this, we calculate the performance of an equal-weighted equity portfolio comprising the 300 largest stocks in our universe, rebalanced monthly. We then add two overlays: one selling call options on the 20% of stocks with the highest scores in our systematic framework, and another on the 20% with the lowest scores. All options sold have a four-week tenor and are structured with a delta of 15 at inception. The notional of options sold is scaled by a factor of two, increasing the overlay's weight to 40% of the long exposure, up from 20%.

Figure 7 - A well-constructed call overwrite can potentially add performance across cycles

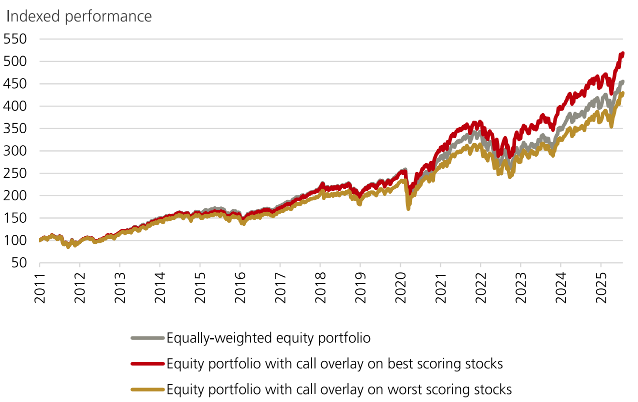

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Figure 7 shows the performance of the three strategies. The strategy with a short call overlay on the highest-scoring stocks performs well and would have outperformed the equal-weighted long-only portfolio over the full sample period. While our focus is on an equal-weighted approach, adding such an overlay to a market-capitalization-weighted portfolio would have yielded similar results.

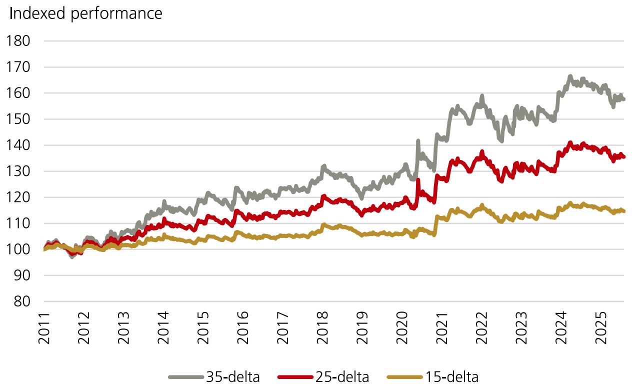
Relative outperformance is typically achieved during equity drawdowns, such as in spring 2020 or during 2022, when elevated option premiums provide additional income and partially offset losses in the underlying equity positions. The strategy would have underperformed during periods of rising markets and low implied volatility. However, the overlay on the best-screening stocks was not a drag during the recovery from the 2020 drawdown, as rich implied volatility compensated option sellers for the upside risk.

Buying cheap volatility

A second application is to systematically buy calls on stocks that screen as "cheap" in our framework. Over the past 15 years, a strategy that systematically bought 1-month call options on the 20 stocks scoring worst in the overwriting framework would have performed well, as illustrated in Figure 8.

Figure 8 - Buying cheap calls delivers interesting return porfile

Systematic strategy which buys calls on stocks scoring the worst for overwriting within our framework.



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Unsurprisingly, investors would typically do the opposite of the overwriting strategy; that is, higher-delta calls tend to be more attractive candidates for buying optionality. While such a strategy—even with higher delta—would not have outperformed a pure equity strategy, we still believe that well-designed, long volatility strategies, can serve as interesting portfolio diversifiers within an asset allocation context. Although the risk-return profile is related to equities, it appears distinctly different. The strategy tends to perform best during periods when implied volatility underestimates future equity market returns, which are not necessarily the periods of the best absolute equity performance. Additionally, drawdowns are limited to the premium spent on optionality. This underlines, once again, the point made throughout this research note: trading an option and trading the underlying, while related, are two distinctly different endeavors.

Appendix

Risks associated to option selling strategies
Investors must understand the risks associated with the structured products that they intend to purchase. This is true for reverse convertibles, which not only expose investors to the risk of the issuer defaulting, but also to market risk associated with the underlying asset. Investors that buy a reverse convertible are selling a put option, which involves the possibility of losing part of their invested capital, should the underlying asset fall significantly below the strike level at expiry. There is also the risk of limited liquidity in the secondary market, which could complicate the daily pricing of the product. Investors should therefore be prepared to hold a reverse convertible until maturity to avoid incurring additional costs or losses. Price transparency can be a problem with certain types of structured products, this is less the case for reverse convertibles. Reverse convertibles are relatively simple products, as they do not contain exotic options. This leads to competition among issuing banks. As for any investment product, investors should be aware of applicable taxation and that past performance is no guarantee for future results. In the case of reverse convertibles, demand and supply for protection (i.e., volatility) may change over time and hence, impact return characteristics.

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Neutral: We do not expect outsized returns or losses. Hold longer-term exposure.
Unattractive: We consider this asset class to be unattractive. Consider alternative opportunities
Note: For equities, we have a five-tier rating system with two additional preferences
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Appendix

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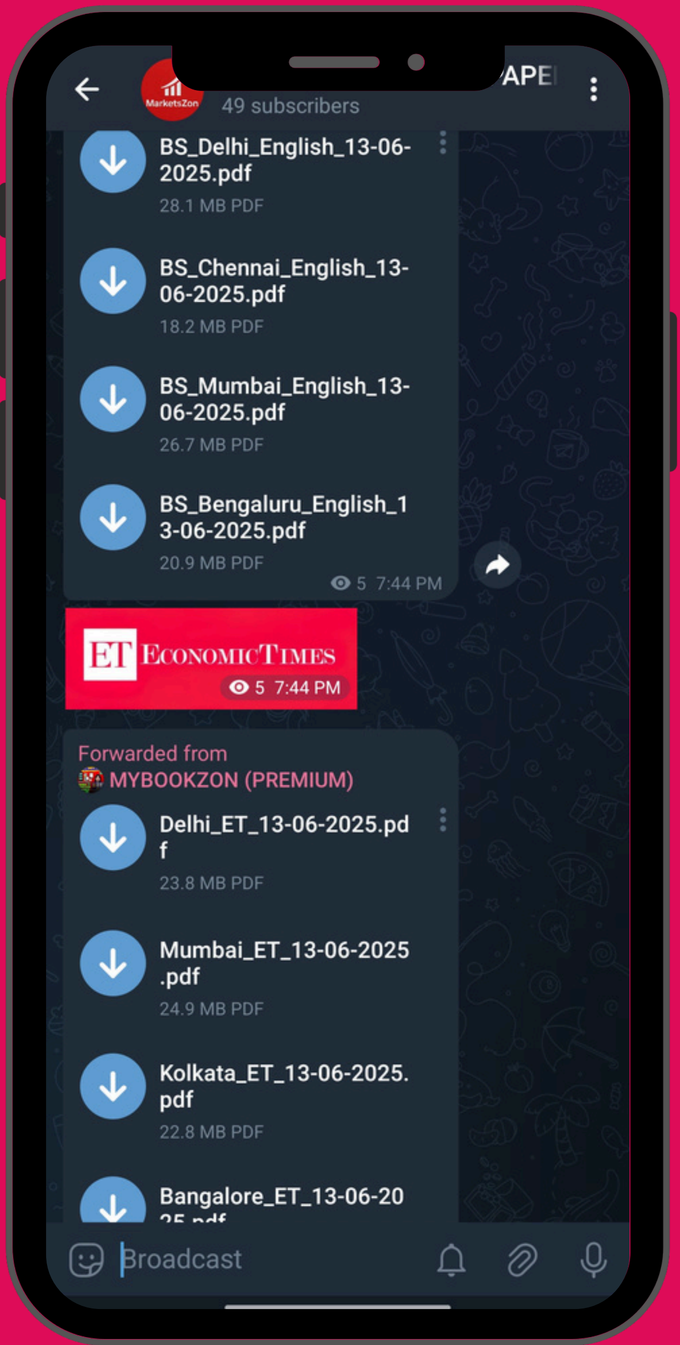

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